



Cashier-less grocery shopping!

Amazon opens its first cashier-less grocery store to make use of the "Just-Walk-Out" technology. <https://dgit.in/mar20-63>



Cheap thrills for the elderly

Apple is conducting a "Heartline" study, which means users above 65 could get an Apple Watch for \$49. <https://dgit.in/mar20-64>

Noise Shots XO

Feature-laden, still not without flaws

Noise has rapidly amassed the reputation of providing competent audio solutions at relatively affordable price points. The company recently launched a new pair of true wireless earphones dubbed the Noise Shots XO priced at ₹5,499 which looks positively appealing on paper. Featuring extravagant features such as wireless charging for the case, a battery life of 36 hours and more, these earphones will certainly have consumers all around vying to purchase them. Let's find out how these earphones fared.

Build and design

The Noise Shots XO are available in three colours - Space Grey, Rose Gold and Metallic White. We received the Rose Gold version which is the most eye-catching one.

The Noise Shots XO has a bulky, circular charging case which resembles a drum. The top part sports a metallic rose gold tint, while the bottom sports a matte, baby pink look. While we give Noise props for going with an unconventional design, the case is far from pocketable. The top portion of the case features a circular dent which you need to swivel to reveal the earphones within. Unfortunately, we found this process quite tedious and not too seamless.

Coming to the buds, they sport a dual finish just like the case. The earphones resemble a teardrop and the rear of the earphones bulge outwards considerably. They do tend to protrude quite a bit from your ear. Still, the fit inside the ear is snug and comfortable.

Features

One of the most prominent features of the Noise Shots XO is the ability to power the charging case wirelessly on any Qi-enabled charger. We were able to juice the charger up to full from almost empty in merely two hours with a 10W wireless charger.



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The battery life of the Noise Shots XO is extremely impressive. It features a total battery of 36 hours, with 6 hours on the buds, while the charging case holds an additional 30 hours, according to the company. In our testing, we were able to extract about 5 hours from the earphones at 70% volume, and we were able to bring the charging case down to 5% battery percentage after charging the earbuds around 5-6 times.

The Noise Shots XO also comes with touch controls, accessible via the rear surface of the buds. The touch panel is slightly indented, which lets you easily rest your finger in the cavity. The touch controls are responsive and work well. However, there's no volume controls present, which is disappointing.

While we've read about a few people facing some issues when pairing the earphones to their smartphones, we faced no such hiccups.

The Noise Shots XO also comes equipped with additional features such as ENC, IPX7 rating, USB Type-C/Wireless fast charging, Qualcomm aptX HD, Mono mode and Bluetooth v5.0.

Performance

Regrettably, sound quality is where the Noise Shots XO really falter. Feature-laden as these earphones are, their appeal really diminishes due to their

muddy, bass-heavy sound profile.

Both, the bass as well as the lows, are extremely exaggerated. They veil most of the fine details in the mids, especially the lower-mids. In *Ludens* by *Bring Me The Horizon*, the bass beats sound extremely cloudy and distorted, while the vocals sound lacklustre due to the boomy lows. This is extremely disappointing since Noise usually manages to maintain a good balance between frequencies.

The vocals, especially male vocals, sound muddy as well. In *Rescue Me* by *OneRepublic* the vocals are relegated to the background with the bass beats completely overpowering the entire song. However, female vocals tend to do slightly better since they are usually above the treacherous zone of auditory masking. The highs are slightly better-sounding, but they are slightly under-extended, which inhibits them from reproducing high notes with precision.

The soundstage and imaging is decent for in-ears. Sadly, the microphone quality is not up to standard as well. The receiver could hear plenty of background sounds and also complained that our voice sounded pretty muffled. The only reason the Noise Shots XO wins back some points in the performance department is that the passive isolation is excellent and there's almost no sound leakage. Additionally, the battery life is also stellar.

Bottomline

The Noise Shots XO sport a relatively affordable price tag and offer a plethora of features, but the poor sound quality is what kills its cause. The aggressive bass and lows maims the overall balance of the sound. Despite the impressive battery life and wireless charging feature, we cannot recommend users to buy the Noise Shots XO due to their poor sound quality and poor microphone quality.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

ITEM WEIGHT: 63.5 g | COMPATIBLE DEVICES: Android and iOS | BLUETOOTH VERSION: v5.0 | IP RATING: IPX7 | CONTROLS: Full Touch | RANGE: 10m | BATTERY LIFE AVERAGE: 36 hours | ADDITIONAL FEATURES: quick pairing, aptX, wireless charging

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